called my friend Atul Ranade and asked him over. When he arrived I told him that I wanted to go for a drive and to visit the Shivaji Park temple.

It felt good praying at well past midnight. It gave me a sense of calm again and helped take my mind off the game. Then we went to the Siddhi Vinayak temple and finally, on our way back to the hotel, decided to have a milkshake at Haji Ali. Strange as it may sound, Atul and I sat on the roadside at 1 a.m. drinking milkshake and relaxing. We talked about anything but cricket and I was feeling much better when I went back to the hotel. I even managed to get some sleep and the following day I made 148.

Unfortunately it didn't bring the win I needed, even though at one point we were in a great position. At a crucial moment in the innings we dropped a catch which would have put them under tremendous pressure. To add to our frustration, it also started drizzling and the game was stopped. I felt it was a combination of missed chances and bad luck that cost us the match.

The Sri Lanka series was followed by a four-nation tournament in Sharjah in December 1997. We played some very poor cricket against England, Pakistan and the West Indies, losing all our matches and failing to make the final. The match against Pakistan on 14 December highlights how things were just not going my way. I was batting at number four in this competition, at the selectors' request. Sourav and Navjot Sidhu had given us a good start against Pakistan, and when Sidhu got out at 143–2, I sent in Robin Singh, the all-rounder, to accelerate the innings. It was a strategy I had given considerable thought to. Manzoor Akhtar, the leg-spinner, was at one end bowling around the wicket to the right-handed batsmen. The theory was that Robin, a left-hander, would be able to negotiate his leg-spin better and also hit some big shots. However, Robin got out without scoring after just three balls from Azhar Mahmood, the medium-pacer, and the experiment proved a disaster.

In the press I was criticized for sending in Robin ahead of me and the move was blamed for our defeat. A month later, however, in January 1998, Azhar, back as captain, repeated the very same move in the final of the Silver Jubilee Independence Cup in Dhaka against Pakistan. Robin was sent in at three to keep up the momentum after Sourav and I had got off to a flier and this time Robin played a terrific hand, scoring 82 and setting up the run chase. This was arguably a bigger gamble, because he was pitted against the off-spinner Saqlain Mushtaq and it is no secret that